

THE JAMIL BLUEPRINT

The Indian men's football team, foundering in the doldrums of mediocrity for the last two years, gets its first **homegrown coach** in 13 years.

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On the evening of February 25, 2022, Khalid Jamil cut a solitary figure on the touchline. His NorthEast United FC side had just lost 2-3 to Jamshedpur FC — one of its 12 defeats that season, a stark contrast to the dream run of 10 unbeaten games he had guided it through in the previous campaign.

"One thing I want to say is that I always take the blame — we win or lose because of me," was one of Jamil's earliest reactions.

Accountability has been one of the biggest virtues of the 48-year-old, media-shy coach. As he embarks on his journey at the helm of the Indian men's national team, he demands it now more than ever, from himself and from his cadres.

"Firstly, it is great to work for the nation. Secondly, we have to take responsibility, and it is my pleasure to accept the challenge," Jamil tells Sportstar in an exclusive interview.

"It is a big one (the opportunity), and it is about the country. We must work together, and the players must also take responsibility for the team. We must work hard as a unit and for India," he adds.

In the last two years, the Indian men's football team has foundered in the doldrums of mediocrity.

It has changed two coaches, Igor Stimac and Manolo Marquez, both of whom were seen pushing the envelope of culpability towards the ecosystem or the players, the opposite of what Jamil has done over the years.

Perhaps that very disposition tipped the scales in his favour as the All India Football Federation (AIFF) anointed him, an indigenous son, over two experienced foreign contenders: Stephen Constantine, who had once helped India climb 76 spots in the FIFA rankings, and Stefan Tarkovic, under whom Slovakia played in the 2020 European Championship.

A keen eye

In his 16-year coaching career, Jamil has managed clubs across the three divisions of Indian men's football and remains the only coach from the country in the Indian Super League (ISL), the current men's top flight.

In his most recent assignment, he took Jamshedpur to the league semifinals and the Super Cup final.

"I think he is fantastic at reading the game because he knows everything about a player (his ability) and can bring 100 per cent out of an individual. Like, if I am not giving my all, he knows how to get that out of me," says Albino Gomes, an integral member of the Jamshedpur side and an I-League winner under Jamil at Aizawl. "In training sessions, he pushes everyone, even if a player thinks he is giving his 100 per cent. That way, that player is motivated to give more."

Jamil became the first Indian full-time coach of the men's senior team in 13 years and just